

NERAI Maritime Weekly

The week's most consequential events, selected by strategic consequence and grounded in a 31-article 7-day corpus plus live NERAI data.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF - The week was dominated by two interlocking crises that are now compounding each other: the US–Iran conflict has driven Strait of Hormuz oil transit to a SEVERE -92.9% versus baseline, while a simultaneous Houthi offensive toward Bab al-Mandeb has pushed that chokepoint into SEVERE territory as well (-33.3% vs baseline). Four corridors are deteriorating on the model and in the water simultaneously, creating a vessel and port-capacity squeeze that transforms rerouting from a cost into a structural constraint. The Taiwan Strait forward disruption probability rose 10.2 points to 54% over four weeks, adding a third, independent axis of risk that markets have not yet fully priced.

01 US–Iran tanker war escalates: Sidr struck, 2 Filipino sailors killed, US destroys 3 Iranian tankers

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-01

WHY IT RANKS - The most consequential maritime security development of the week: a direct exchange of lethal force between US and Iranian naval assets in the world's most critical oil chokepoint, driving Hormuz transit to a SEVERE -92.9% versus baseline and raising the credible prospect of full closure extending into 2027.

On 1 September 2026 a tanker was hit by three unknown projectiles while transiting the Strait of Hormuz, according to the UK Maritime Trade Operations agency. Saudi shipping company Bahri confirmed the vessel as the tanker Sidr and reported two Filipino sailors killed in the incident; Saudi Arabia formally accused Iran of the attack. In response, the United States said it destroyed three Iranian oil tankers after IRGC missile attacks on US Navy ships. Iran subsequently warned of a 'more painful' retaliation and, as of 7 September, was reported to be planning a new 'restricted' maritime zone in the area.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The tit-for-tat exchange marks a qualitative escalation from skirmish to sustained naval combat, with both sides now destroying flagged commercial vessels as instruments of coercion. The NERAI Hormuz oil-flow reading of 1.5 mb/d (-92.9% vs baseline, observed 2026-09-07) confirms that the physical market is already pricing a near-closure; the four-week forward disruption probability of 51% means markets assign roughly even odds that the corridor remains contested through October. A Japanese tanker giant's warning that disruptions could drag into next year, reported 3 September, signals that major operators are already shifting from tactical avoidance to strategic fleet repositioning. The IMF, per a 3 September report, warned of rising debt pressure on developing economies from the Hormuz closure, underscoring that the impact extends well beyond energy importers to sovereign-credit markets. Iran's threat of a new restricted maritime zone, if declared, would generate immediate P&I and war-risk cover reviews and could trigger JWC listed-area re-designation across the Persian Gulf, adding a compliance layer on top of the physical risk. Saudi Arabia's condemnation of Iran and the killing of Filipino nationals internationalises the crew-welfare dimension, potentially drawing the Philippines and other seafarer-supplying states into diplomatic pressure on both parties.

NERAI SIGNAL - Hormuz oil flow: 1.5 mb/d, -92.9% vs baseline (SEVERE); 4-week disruption probability 51% (NERAI corridor forecast, observed 2026-09-07).

Sources: moneycontrol.com: <https://www.moneycontrol.com/world/tanker-hit-by-three-unknown-projectiles-while-transiting-strait-of-hormuz-says-uk-maritime-agency-article-14019366.html> | indiablooms.com: <https://www.indiablooms.com/world/us-says-it-destroyed-3-iranian-oil-tankers-after-irgc-missile-attacks-on-navy-ships/details> | tradearabia.com: <https://tradearabia.com:443/News/467645/Iran-warns-of-%E2%80%98more-painful%E2%80%99-response-plans-new-restricted-maritime-zone>

02 Houthi offensive toward Bab al-Mandeb kills 129, pushes Bab el-Mandeb flow to SEVERE

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-05

WHY IT RANKS - A major ground offensive by Houthis toward the strait that controls the southern entry to the Red Sea now threatens to close the alternative rerouting corridor that shipping has used since the Hormuz crisis began, creating a simultaneous two-chokepoint squeeze with no unconstrained bypass.

Houthi forces launched a ground offensive toward Bab al-Mandab during the week, with sources reporting 81 dead by 4 September and the toll rising to 129 dead by 5 September, described as Yemen's worst clashes in years. Gulf News reported on 6 September that the offensive is directly linked to the Hormuz disruption, with Houthis exploiting the crisis to push toward the strait. NERAI data shows Bab el-Mandeb oil flow falling to 5.8 mb/d, -33.3% versus baseline (SEVERE), a status deterioration from STRAINED, and Djibouti port calls falling a further 86.7 points to -33.4% versus the 90-day average.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The compound risk identified in the NERAI change block — four corridors deteriorating on the model and in the water simultaneously — is now manifest in its most dangerous form: Hormuz is already SEVERE and Bab el-Mandeb has just crossed into SEVERE as well. Vessels that have been avoiding Hormuz by loading at alternative terminals and transiting south are now exposed to a second threat vector at Bab al-Mandeb, eliminating the straightforward reroute logic that underpinned early crisis response. Djibouti, the principal bunkering and transshipment hub for Red Sea–Indian Ocean traffic, showing a SEVERE DROP in port calls further reduces the logistical resilience available to operators. The Red Sea / Bab-el-Mandeb four-week forward disruption probability stands at 46% (observed 2026-09-07), and the flow status change from STRAINED to SEVERE since 30 August means the model and the water are moving in the same direction — a convergence that NERAI flags as

the condition that turns rerouting into a structural cost rather than a tactical adjustment. War-risk underwriters will need to reassess cumulative exposure across both theatres simultaneously, and P&I; clubs may face overlapping crew-welfare and hull claims if the offensive reaches the strait's immediate approaches.

NERAI SIGNAL - Bab el-Mandeb oil flow: 5.8 mb/d, -33.3% vs baseline (SEVERE); Djibouti port calls -33.4% vs 90-day average (SEVERE DROP); Red Sea/Bab-el-Mandeb 4-week disruption probability 46% (NERAI corridor forecast, observed 2026-09-07).

Sources: thehindu.com: <https://www.thehindu.com/news/international/more-than-120-killed-in-yemens-worst-clashes-in-years-sources/article71429714.ece> | gulfnews.com: <https://gulfnews.com/world/gulf/yemen/why-iran-backed-houthi-militants-are-pushing-towards-bab-al-mandab-as-hormuz-disruption-raises-stakes-1.500664538> | samaa.tv: <https://www.samaa.tv/2087356290-yemen-houthi-offensive-leaves-129-dead-over-bab-al-mandab>

03 Taiwan Strait 4-week disruption probability surges 10 points to 54% — highest in corpus

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-07

WHY IT RANKS - The Taiwan Strait forward probability rose 10.2 points to 54% over four weeks, the largest single-corridor risk jump in the NERA change block, opening a third independent axis of shipping disruption at the moment global fleet capacity is already being consumed by Hormuz and Bab al-Mandeb avoidance.

NERAI corridor data observed on 7 September 2026 shows the Taiwan Strait four-week disruption probability at 54%, up 10.2 points since 30 August, with the eight-week probability at 81%, up 6.0 points over the same period. The two-week probability rose 7.4 points to 17%. The South China Sea four-week probability also rose 3.8 points to 54% over the same window. Both corridors carry a sanctions score of 93/100, the highest in the NERA dataset.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - A 10-point rise in four-week forward probability over eight days is a material signal shift, not a marginal drift, and it arrives at a moment when the global fleet has already absorbed months of Hormuz rerouting pressure. Container and drybulk scores for the Taiwan Strait sit at 49/100, consistent with a corridor operating near but not yet below its risk threshold, meaning the forward probability is moving ahead of observed physical disruption — a leading-indicator pattern that warrants watch-list elevation. The South China Sea moving in parallel (54% at four weeks, +3.8 points) suggests a regional deterioration rather than a strait-specific anomaly. Should disruption materialise in either corridor, the pool of uncommitted vessel capacity available to absorb additional rerouting demand from Hormuz or Bab al-Mandeb would shrink further, transmitting cost pressure across all three theatres simultaneously. The high sanctions score (93/100) in both corridors means compliance teams face layered exposure: geopolitical escalation risk overlapping with sanctions-screening intensity for any call at ports in or adjacent to these waters.

NERAI SIGNAL - Taiwan Strait 4-week disruption probability: 54% (+10.2 points since 2026-08-30); 8-week probability: 81% (+6.0 points). South China Sea 4-week probability: 54% (+3.8 points). (NERAI corridor forecast, observed 2026-09-07).

Sources: businesstoday.in: <https://www.businesstoday.in/world/story/global-trade-runs-on-the-oceans-10-maritime-chokepoints-that-could-disrupt-the-world-economy-553470-2026-09-07>

04 Japanese tanker giant warns Hormuz disruptions could drag into 2027 as commercial avoidance deepens

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-09-03

WHY IT RANKS - A major commercial operator publicly extending its disruption horizon to next year is a consequential market signal: it shifts fleet deployment decisions, long-term charter pricing and insurance renewal cycles from tactical to structural planning.

A Japanese tanker company warned on 3 September 2026 that Hormuz disruptions could drag into next year, according to a report by OilPrice.com. Separately, UKMTO reported on 5 September that maritime traffic through Hormuz was significantly reduced. OilPrice.com reported on 2 September that Hormuz traffic had cratered to four ships as Iran–US strikes escalated, and a Times of India report from 1 September noted vessels entering the strait had fallen below the 10-day average.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - When a major tanker operator publicly shifts from a weeks-to-months disruption horizon to a months-to-year horizon, it signals that the internal probability assessment has crossed the threshold at which tactical rerouting is replaced by structural fleet repositioning — longer voyages, different load-port arrangements and likely renegotiation of time-charter terms. NERA's four-week Hormuz disruption probability of 51% and eight-week probability of 77% (observed 2026-09-07) are consistent with that operator's assessment, and the alignment of commercial and model signals strengthens the case for treating this as a sustained rather than episodic disruption. The physical Hormuz oil flow of 1.5 mb/d (-92.9% vs baseline) already reflects near-closure conditions; the operator warning suggests that even partial recovery is not expected before 2027. For importers of Gulf crude — particularly in South and East Asia — this extends the planning horizon for alternative supply sourcing, port-of-loading diversification and strategic stock drawdowns well beyond the current quarter.

NERAI SIGNAL - Hormuz oil flow: 1.5 mb/d, -92.9% vs baseline (SEVERE); 8-week disruption probability 77% (NERAI corridor forecast, observed 2026-09-07).

Sources: oilprice.com: <https://oilprice.com/Latest-Energy-News/World-News/Hormuz-Disruptions-Could-Drag-Into-Next-Year-Japanese-Tanker-Giant-Warns.html> | middleeasteye.net: <https://www.middleeasteye.net/live-blog/live-blog-update/maritime-traffic-through-hormuz-significantly-reduced-ukmto-says> | oilprice.com: <https://oilprice.com/Latest-Energy-News/World-News/Hormuz-Traffic-Craters-to-Four-Ships-as-Iran-US-Strikes-Escalate.html>

WITHHELD BY THE TEMPORAL GATE - Bosporus oil flow deteriorates 15.6 points to -26.6% vs baseline, crossing into STRAINED (event dated 2026-08-30, before the window, not labelled FOLLOW-UP)

Grounded generation: events are selected only from the week's retrieved article corpus and NERAI feeds; every event carries its sources; each event states the date the issuing authority acted, which is distinct from the date any article about it was published; quantitative figures carry their observation period; maximum five events, fewer when the week is thin. NERAI-UNRESTRICTED.